

English 11- SSTM Project

Start Something That Matters to You and the World! **Create a business; then design a website to promote it.**

Have you ever thought about running your own business? Working for yourself with no boss to answer to? Providing a product or service to people that helps make their lives better?

In this unit, we will read *Start Something That Matters* (SSTM). This is Blake Mycoskie's first-hand account of how he created the multimillion dollar company, TOMS shoes. He built TOMS from the ground up using his own creativity, hard work, and passion. His dream was not just to create a successful company, but also to help make people's lives a little bit better.

As you read SSTM, you'll be thinking about how **Blake's story of building TOMS** could apply to a **business of your own**. After reading and discussing key chapters, you'll **create a website for the business that explains what you're selling** (expository content) and **shows why customers will want your product or service** (persuasive content). You'll also **create a compelling backstory** for your company (narrative content) to help make a **personal connection between your business and your customers**.

Here's how this will work:

We'll read and discuss the book in class. Then, you'll build a website for your own business.

Unit Overview:

- ★ **Reading:** You will read SSTM in class.
- ★ **Questions & Quizzes:** You will answer questions about each chapter and take quizzes that cover several chapters.
- ★ **Connections:** Throughout the reading, you'll update a "connections chart" to think about how Blake's business start-up story applies to starting your own.
- ★ **Website Project:** Your final project will be the website you build to explain and promote your business.

The Website Project has 3 steps. You will complete each step in class.

Project DAY 1: Describe your company, create a logo, write your mission statement

Project DAY 2: Determine your qualifications and target market

Project DAYS 3 & 4: Build a website that explains and promotes your product to its target audience(s).

You never know—the business you create in class could become your own company someday!

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DAY 1: Describe your company, create a logo, write your mission statement

Remember: Your mission statement is a summary of the goals and values of a company, organization, or individual.

Read these sample business scenarios (descriptions) to help you get started:

Business 1: Building a better mousetrap:	Perhaps you want to position your mousetrap for a primarily upscale market because the best design requires titanium and manufacturing costs will be so expensive that only rich people will be able to afford your product. But maybe the mousetrap is so fantastically effective that wealthy people will want hundreds of them around their vast country homes and polo pony barns.
Business 2: Starting a restaurant	Will your restaurant make people's palates delirious with new taste sensations? Will your new mousetrap help people capture mice without feeling sick to their stomachs?
Business 3: Creating a scented bubble bath	Will this revolutionize the way children agree to take nightly baths?

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Step 1: Describe your company.

Please answer these questions below to help your thinking. Try to be as specific as possible in your responses. You'll probably have to do some research online.

1. What products and or services will you produce or provide?

Be specific. For example, if you're starting a salon products business, what kind of products will you sell? Will you focus on just hand products, or body products? Will you offer in-person service, or just sell items online?

My company, **2 The Sky Motorsports**, specializes in **high-performance tuning and custom builds**. We take cars people already love: muscle cars, imports, exotics, or track builds, and make them faster, stronger, and sharper. Services include:

- ECU tuning and dyno testing for maximum horsepower.
- Performance upgrades (turbos, superchargers, exhaust, intake, intercoolers).
- Custom suspension setups for track or street dominance.
- High-end braking systems for serious stopping power.
- Precision engine builds and swaps.
- Custom aesthetics (carbon fiber parts, aero kits, racing interiors).

We'll be a shop where enthusiasts go to push their machines to the limit, not just fix daily commuters.

2. What will your product or service enable people to do better, more cheaply, more safely, more efficiently? *You must have a reason why your business will succeed. This is the competitive advantage your product or service will offer.*

- **Better:** Cars will run faster, handle sharper, and perform at peak potential.
- **Cheaper:** Instead of overpriced dealership "sport packages," customers get real horsepower gains for a better value.

Start Something that Matters Project Instructions - English 11

- **Safer:** Builds are done with pro-level tuning and parts, no sketchy backyard mods. Drivers get speed and reliability.
- **Efficient:** Our streamlined shop model with dyno and tuning in-house means faster turnaround from stock to street-ready.

Competitive advantage: We don't just "repair cars." **We build legends.** Customers don't leave with a car that just works. They leave with a car that **thrills**.

3. How can you make your company more noticeable than your competitors?

You will need to make your company stand out from other, similar businesses.

Examples of ways to make your company noticeable may include:

- *A compelling backstory (How did you company start? What is its mission? What obstacles did the company have to overcome?)*
- *Drive people to your company website through ads, flyers, contests*
- *Get good reviews of your company from professionals in your industry*
- *Get "regular" people talking about your company (word of mouth through influencers, friends)*

List specific tools you will use on your website to make your company/products/services stand out (Use your Non Fiction Styles/Types/Tools Resource Doc for reference.)

- **Compelling backstory:** Founded by gearheads who grew up wrenching on junkyard projects, racing them, blowing them up, and coming back stronger until we learned how to build machines that could dominate.
- **Marketing strategy:**
 - Sick build videos and dyno runs on YouTube, TikTok, and Instagram.
 - Host "dyno day" events where customers can bring cars, test them, and show off.
 - Sponsorships of local drift teams and car meets.
- **Reviews & credibility:** Car YouTubers and influencers test-drive our builds.
- **Word of mouth:** When someone shows up at a car meet with a 700hp daily driver, everyone's asking, "*Who built that?*"

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Build Portfolio

A gallery page with professional photos, dyno charts, and short cinematic videos of past projects.

👉 View the Portfolio (*sample link for style inspiration*)

Horsepower Calculator

An interactive tool where users can choose their car model, select upgrades, and instantly see estimated horsepower and torque gains.

👉 Try a Horsepower Calculator (*example embed — we'd customize it with our own builds and data*)

Virtual Garage

A web-based configurator where customers can spec their car with different wheels, body kits, paint, and performance parts before booking.

👉 Check Out a Virtual Garage Example (*inspiration: Ford's Mustang build configurator*)

Customer Spotlight Section

A dedicated blog/feature page showing off customer builds, before-and-after shots, and owner interviews.

👉 See Example Features (*inspiration from StanceWorks community builds*)

Merch Store

An e-commerce page to buy **2 the Sky Motorsports** gear: hats, tees, hoodies, and stickers.

👉 Sample Store Layout (*Hoonigan is a perfect example of merging car culture + merch*)

Specific tools for the website:

- **Build portfolio** with photos, dyno charts, and videos of our best projects.
- **Horsepower calculator** (shows potential gains from different upgrades).
- **Virtual garage** where customers can spec out a build before coming in.
- **Customer spotlight section** featuring their rides after we've worked on them.
- **Merch store** (hats, tees, hoodies with the 2 the Sky Motorsports logo).

DAY 2: Brainstorm the following important aspects of your company

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Skills and Qualifications

What skills and qualifications are necessary to start this business and make it a success?

Skills could include any of the following: education, personal experience, work experience, creative talents etc.

What skills and qualifications will you need?

What skills or qualifications do you already have?

Demographics - Analyzing the Market for your Business

Demographics are important for businesses because they help with:

Product design: Businesses can tailor products to meet the needs of different groups.

Marketing: Businesses can tailor marketing efforts to meet the needs of different groups.

Business location: Businesses can choose locations that are best suited to their target market.

Evaluate demographics -Who are your customers/clients? Use the following questions to guide your thinking.

Brainstorm these questions about the demographics of your prime market will help you establish clear characteristics of the people you need to reach. (Demographic analysis)

1. What age group(s) will be interested in your product/service?
2. What do they do for a living?
3. Will a particular gender want your service more than another?
4. Is your product or service attractive to a particular ethnic or economic group of people?
5. Will only wealthy people be able to afford it?
6. Does your ideal customer live in a certain type of neighborhood, and does this make a difference?

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For example, if you are selling soap, you may believe that every dirty body needs your product, but you can't start with the entire world as your initial market. Even if you've developed such a universally needed item as soap, you need to identify a smaller, more targeted customer group first, such as children under eight who might like bubblegum- scented bubble bath. How many children in the United States are currently under the age of eight? How much soap will they use in a month or a year? How many other soap manufacturers already have a share of the market? How big are your potential competitors?

Brainstorm demographic questions here:

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DAY 3: Marketing Your Business-Create a Website

Create a website that describes your business and promotes your products and services. Change potential customers to committed supporters!

Marketing helps you focus on identifying your **competitive advantage**; it also establishes the **best ways to reach your potential customers** and what to say to them. Marketing describes the way you will **position your product or service within your target market**. Concentrate on the competitive advantages you identified. As you build your website, use the following questions to guide your thinking:

1. Will your product or service distinguish itself by its superior quality, its revolutionary features or its ability to make your customers happier than they've ever been in their lives?
2. What will you say to persuade and convince customers that your product or service is better, more useful, etc?
3. Who is your target audience? Consider the demographics of your customer base, so it appeals to those groups.
4. What will your site look like? How will you make your site appealing to your target audience? Think about design (font, colors, images, navigation).

Your website should include:

1. Your company name & logo
2. Company description and mission statement, and “your story” (“About” page)
3. Product information presented clearly and creatively to target your audience(s)

Create your website using Canva or Google Sites.

Look at sample sites: [Wayfair](#) (home decor), [TOMS](#), [Ranger Rick](#) (kids nature magazine), [Cornerstones](#) (community outreach to underprivileged), [DoSomething](#) (Advocacy resource)

A good website is easy to use, visually appealing, and has relevant content.

Be sure to include necessary information about your product or service that targets your customer base. Use the demographic information you discovered to decide how to best present your product or service.

Start Something that Matters Project Instructions - English 11

Consider the following when designing your website. Use the RUBRIC to make sure you have included all required elements.

Content:

Quality: Content should be engaging, relevant, and informative.

Freshness: Search engines and visitors prefer fresh content.

Clarity: Use clear and concise writing to convey information effectively.

Relevance: Address the needs, interests, and challenges of your target audience.

Navigation:

Ease of use: Make it easy for users to find what they're looking for.

Consistency: Keep navigation consistent from page to page.

Intuitiveness: Help users understand and interact with your website.

Design:

Responsive: Make sure your website looks good and works well on all devices.

Visuals: Use strong visuals to establish brand identity and credibility.

Copyright: Use copyright free images (Creative Commons)

Use Expository, Narrative, and Persuasive Tools to make your site engaging for users!

Skills:

1. Use Non Fiction Communication techniques to create a strong, targeted message.

Include at least three tools from each of the Non Fiction styles:

Expository: internal and external text structures

Narrative: descriptive language, story-telling including plot events, figurative language

Persuasive: Logos, Pathos, and Ethos strategies

Use the Non Fiction Styles, Types, and Tools Resource Chart to remind yourself of the tools.

2. **Write a Reflection Paragraph** in which you identify the tools that you used to create your website and share challenges and successes.

Have fun with this! Turn customers into supporters and engage in Conscious Capitalism!